FOLLOWING JESUS

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Welcome, we are so excited to take this journey with you.

Welcome to Following Jesus at Garden City Church! Our sincere prayer throughout this journey is for you to draw nearer to God, and have a clear understanding of your next steps in faith. While many churches urge people to "accept Jesus and follow Him," the specifics can often feel elusive. What does it truly mean to be a Christ-follower? What are we supposed to do? How can we embody the teachings of Jesus in our daily lives? At Garden City Church, we want to make the path of following Jesus simple and clear, and walk it together as a community.

Whether you're new to the church scene, recently baptized, or have been a lifelong churchgoer, this class is designed for you. It's common to hold misconceptions about God, and this course not only introduces the foundational principles of following Christ but also offers a fresh perspective on traditional doctrines, making them relevant and applicable to modern life.

Fundamentally, every follower of Jesus is called to make disciples. Yet, to fulfill this calling, we must first live out the teachings ourselves. Imagine embarking on flight lessons with an instructor who lacks fundamental knowledge of flying, leaving you ill-equipped to navigate the skies, and then hands over the controls for you to ‘wing-it’. Similarly, without a solid understanding of the core beliefs and practices of Christianity, we cannot effectively pass on these teachings and many are ‘winging-it’.

This class serves as the cornerstone of discipleship at Garden City Church. Each session will delve into practical aspects of Christian living, such as prayer, Bible study, and embodying Christ's love. Moreover, these discussions will take place within the supportive environment of community, enriching our understanding and strengthening our bonds.

We are thrilled by your commitment to follow Christ. Your active participation and consistency will deepen your relationship with God and fellow believers and enrich our community.
The more we look like Jesus, the more we can show Jesus to a world that is in deep-desperate need of Him.

Blessings,



Pastor Aaron Rios

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All scripture is referenced from the CSB translation unless otherwise noted.

Setting Expectations

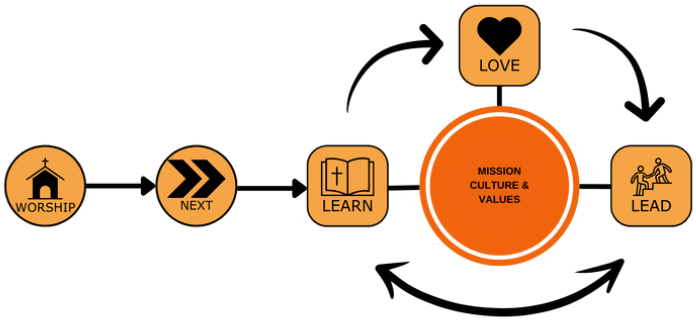
AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH

Mission
Live the life. Tell the Story.

Vision
To know Christ and make Him known in our city and in every nation.

Process: 2 Steps - 3 Phases
Worship + NEXT = Learn, Love, Lead

Step Into Community



BEING A GROUP LEADER

If you are in this class as a facilitator or a breakout group leader, you have a critical role. Anyone who leads in the church, in any capacity, must take seriously the words of Jesus. He made clear:

"You know that the rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them, and those in high positions act as tyrants over them. It must not be like that among you. On the contrary, whoever wants to become great among you must be your servant, and whoever wants to be first among you must be your slave; just as the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (Matthew 20:25-28).

You are to be a servant leader.

- A servant leader has high integrity. If you don't know the answer, say that. But then research the answer and follow up later.
- A servant leader listens to others. When people speak, no matter what they are saying, you intently and carefully listen.
- Servant leaders are consistent. Show up for others each and every week. Stay in contact with those you serve.
- Servant leaders work hard for others. Read through the material and be prepared for those you lead.

Your commitment will influence the way others grow and follow Jesus. You are essential to this process!

BEING A PARTICIPANT

The first century Jesus follower, John—the beloved disciple—challenges us in his first letter by clarifying the goal of every Christ follower. He says it like this:

> *"This is how we know that we know him: if we keep His commands. The one who says, "I have come to know Him," and yet doesn't keep his commands, is a liar, and the truth is not in him. But whoever keeps his word, truly in him the love of God is made complete. This is how we know we are in Him: The one who says He remains in him should walk just as He walked."*
> –1 John 2:3-6

We are supposed to live exactly like Jesus did. That's a high calling. Yet, becoming like Jesus doesn't happen overnight. We believe it happens in steps. One step at a time we become more like Jesus. However, each step must be deliberate and intentional. The fact that you are in this group is a step. But you must take one step after another.

Commit to the next step. First, commit to showing up every week. Second, commit to learning as much as you can by participating and asking questions. Third, commit to practicing what you learn. Finally, commit to taking the next step each week as next steps are presented. You will be given opportunities to serve and connect: take the next step!

WHAT EXACTLY IS SALVATION?

Are you saved? It's a question many churches ask, and they're eager to help you find the answer. Salvation is a big concept, woven throughout the Bible—it's the heart of the gospel message, and it is by far the most important question of your life. Let's break it down.

In the beginning, God created everything, including us, out of love. He made us in His image so we could love Him and others. But with the ability to love comes the gift of free choice - a choice to love God or, simply put, not love God. Sadly, humans chose not to love God, and they demonstrated that by disobeying God, as we see in the story of Adam and Eve. Disobedience opened the door to sickness, disease, brokenness, and death.

God didn't give up on us, God had a plan! He chose a special group of people, the Israelites, to show His love and bring redemption to the world. He gave them laws, kings, and prophets to guide them, but they kept messing up. Their story mirrors our own struggles with sin.

So God sent His Son, Jesus, to rescue everyone - not just His 'special group of people'- once and for all. Jesus was born into the world as a humble baby, part of King David's family. He lived a perfect life, showing us what it means to be truly obedient to God. But He didn't just teach us— he also dealt with sickness, disease, brokenness and death - the consequences of the original disobedience. He took all of it - our sin - on Himself, dying on the cross to save us. And the incredible part? He rose from the dead, proving He's the King over everything and offering us hope in life.

When we choose to turn away from our sins and trust in Jesus, we're saved. It's not about doing more good deeds than bad ones or earning our way to heaven. It's about faith in Jesus and living a life of obedience to Him. He wants us to *'live the life'* that He purchased on that cross.

THE BIBLE SAYS:

"For by grace you have been saved through faith. And this is not your own doing; it is the gift of God, not a result of works, so that no one may boast" - Ephesians 2:8–9

"If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins and purify us from all unrighteousness." - John 1:9

So we are saved by placing our confidence in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus - that's what we call "receiving Jesus by faith." We accept what He has done as sufficient.

But here's the thing: Faith without action is empty. If we truly believe in Jesus, our lives will show it. We'll love others, serve our communities, and live in a way that honors God. Following Jesus isn't just about saying a prayer—it's a lifelong commitment, like a marriage. Just like a marriage takes effort every day, following Jesus means investing in our relationship with Him. Our life should *tell the story* of who Jesus is and what he has done.

So, are you saved? It's not just about saying the words—it's about living them out every day. If you're ready to commit to following Jesus, this journey is for you. It's a worthwhile investment in your relationship with God. Here at Garden City Church, we want to help you *live the life and tell the story*.

BIG IDEA:
Once we have come to a belief in the Gospel and repented of our sins, trusting in Jesus as our Lord and Savior, we then have to be obedient. The Following Jesus process is about the essential beliefs and practices for a life of obedience as a follower of Christ.

Week 1 - Prayer & Worship

“Prayer is the exercise of drawing on the grace of God.” –Oswald Chambers

One of the first Jesus followers, Matthew, recorded Jesus as saying this: “When you pray, don’t babble like the Gentiles, since they imagine they’ll be heard for their many words. Don’t be like them, because your Father knows the things you need before you ask him” (Matthew 6:7-8). Jesus assumes we will be praying as His followers, which is why He says when you are praying, not if you are praying. It should be such an integral practice as a Jesus follower that it is assumed! But Jesus also warns that prayer does not happen out of mindless, religious repetition.

CHALLENGES IN PRAYER

Prayer is a spiritual act, and we are waging a spiritual war. Our spiritual enemy’s goal is to discourage, distract, and cause us to doubt the effectiveness of prayer. This is why prayer is difficult.

Prayer is a Gift

Prayer serves as God’s second way of talking to us, with the Bible being the first. It’s a vital part of walking the path of Jesus. It’s God’s way of saying, "Let’s chat." Prayer has the power to change us and those around us. Like breathing, it’s essential; we can’t go without it. Despite its importance, staying consistent in prayer can be tough. But it’s worth it because prayer is a gift from the God who made us, saved us, and wants us to spend time with Him.

My Prayer Wasn’t Answered, Why?

One of the biggest challenges in prayer is the struggle with prayers that aren’t answered in the way we would hope. Sometimes God answers no. Such as when Jesus asked for His cup to be removed. But God’s no is for the greater good of His Kingdom. Some people sincerely and authentically cry out to God, yet things don’t change in the way they think they should.

Sometimes our unanswered prayers are about the state of our own soul. But sometimes it has nothing to do with our disposition. At times, our prayers may be fundamentally unanswerable.

C.S Lewis notes in his book, *A Grief Observed*, “Can a mortal ask questions which God finds unanswerable? Quite easily, I should think. All nonsense questions are unanswerable. How many hours are in a mile? Is yellow square or round? Probably half the questions we ask - half our great theological and metaphysical problems - are like that.” Sometimes we may be asking the wrong things of an almighty God.

Despite Our Doubts

C.S. Lewis also highlights how critical prayer is for us despite our questions. He says, “I pray because I can’t help myself. I pray because I’m helpless. I pray because the need flows out of me all the time, waking and sleeping. It doesn’t change God. It changes me.”

When we start with the idea that we can do nothing to help ourselves, that we are powerless, God can then move in us and help us through our words and cries.

AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH

We passionately believe in the power of prayer. It is not our last resort, it is our first resolve. Pray first, and pray always. We believe, coupled with the Word, prayer is indeed one of the most powerful tools at a Christian's disposal. Prayer can bring healing, and deliverance and touch the throne of God. We offer morning (5 AM) intercession, Tuesday prayer services, and continue to provide opportunities and develop helpful ways to teach and engage you in the power of prayer.

A MODEL FOR PRAYER

The Lord's Prayer, as taught by Jesus, is a profound and comprehensive model for prayer. It begins with the address "Our Father," signifying the intimate relationship believers have with God as His children. Imagine when you pray “Our Father,” you are linking through time and space with all who have come before you - you are praying to the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. You are praying to the Father whom Jesus prayed to in the Garden. Wow! What an incredible image. This title evokes the image of God walking among His creation in the book of Genesis, highlighting His desire for personal connection despite humanity's separation due to sin.

In Luke's Gospel, Jesus emphasizes the importance of persistent prayer through the parable of the persistent widow, illustrating God's responsiveness to those who continually seek Him. This reinforces the notion that prayer is a powerful tool for touching the heart of God as seen in the story of the unjust judge.

Central to the Lord's Prayer is the plea for God's kingdom to come and His will to be done, on earth as it is in heaven (Matthew 6:10). Remember, you cannot pray “thy kingdom come” while grasping on to your own kingdom. You cannot pray “thy will be done” without first releasing your will to His. When we pray for God’s will, His desire is for all to be saved and come to a knowledge of the truth, as stated in 1 Timothy 2:3-4.

The prayer also includes petitions for daily provision and forgiveness, acknowledging our dependence on God's sustenance and mercy (Matthew 6:11-12). Through forgiveness, we mirror God's graciousness and are reminded of the need to cleanse our hearts from sin, as expressed in Psalms 51:10.

Moreover, the prayer addresses the importance of resisting temptation and evil, seeking God's deliverance and purification (Matthew 6:13). This aligns with the biblical injunction to resist the devil and draw near to God (James 4:7-8).

The concluding doxology, "For Thine is the kingdom and the power and the glory forever, Amen," acknowledges God's sovereignty and majesty (Matthew 6:13). It emphasizes the worshipful aspect of prayer, recognizing God's holiness and worthiness to receive honor and praise (Revelation 4:11).

In essence, the Lord's Prayer serves as a guide for believers, encompassing reverence for God, submission to His will, dependence on His provision, repentance for sin, resistance against evil, and worship of His majesty. It encapsulates the multifaceted nature of prayer and underscores the transformative power of communing with God.

Praise and Thanks - Psalms 100:4-5

The Bible actually tells us when we come to God, to enter in with a grateful heart. Too often we rush in with our shopping list. But as we’ve learned, God knows our needs, so begin with gratitude.

Repent - John 1:9

While some have said there is no need to repent, to the contrary, the Bible teaches living a life of continual repentance - turning away from our daily sins and continual confession. Keep bringing your shortcomings to God. When we repent, we are removing any obstruction to our prayers.

All Others - Ephesians 6:18

We then ask God to help those around us: neighbors, family, friends, leaders, and our world (for their healing; physically and spiritually). It’s important to write down who we are praying for and what specifically we are asking. Then we can go back and see how God has answered our prayers.

Yourself

Finally, we pray for our personal needs and wants in our own lives. This is not going back to repentance - its moving forward to petition.

DID YOU KNOW?

Prayer engages the fullness of God. When we pray, we pray in Jesus' name to God the Father through the Holy Spirit. Imagine God the Father as a cell tower, Jesus as the phone, and the Holy Spirit as the signal being transmitted. A phone call needs all components to work properly. Similarly, in prayer, we utilize the fullness of God in a miraculous way.

Prayer

HOW DOES GARDEN CITY CHURCH PRACTICE PRAYER?

In Luke's second account of Jesus and His followers, he notes that Jesus' followers had a number of consistent practices every time they gathered. He writes this: "They devoted themselves to the apostles' teaching (Acts 2:42-47), to fellowship, to the breaking of bread, and to prayer." (Acts 2:42). We will address the first two further in the Following Jesus process. However, it's clear from Scripture that prayer is a big part of the corporate gathering of Jesus followers. In every service where we gather together, we should pray. This is because our gatherings are dependent on God and not the people leading it. There are intentional times of prayer in corporate gatherings, especially leading into our time of singing and praise. Prayer will look different in different gatherings. Nonetheless, it's important prayer is done with the gathering of Jesus followers. It's a signal that the service is looking toward God and not people for direction and hope.

In our services you may notice a Prayer Team at the end of the pastor's message. This is an opportunity for people to join in prayer with another Jesus follower. There are many reasons why someone may come forward to pray. You can pray with someone because of your gratitude to God, a sin in your life, for someone who is in need, or perhaps your own needs. We are strategic about having people pray with others because prayer is supposed to be done in community.



AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH

Our pastors and designated intercessors are available for prayer at the end of every Sunday service. We want to be a prayerful community. If God speaks during times of prayer, then we want to listen for direction and clarity.

Worship

"Most adults will contend that a Christian has a responsibility to worship God. However, when asked to define what worship means, two out of three are unable to offer an appropriate definition or description of worship."
–George Barna

WHAT IS WORSHIP?

Churches are often associated with the idea of ritual. The times we gather, the songs we sing, the order of services, and the holidays we celebrate are all ritualistic. Liturgical churches are most often identified as ritualistic because of their set movements, predictability, and comfort of their services. Rituals are formal and repetitive in nature. However, churches are not the only things that can be viewed as ritualistic. Anything we do over and over becomes our liturgy, or the work of our ritual. If we were to wake up every Sunday morning, eat breakfast, read the paper, watch football, take a nap, then do some casual lawn work - that is a ritual. Rituals are both religious and non-religious in nature. Therefore, rituals are not worship, but what we have ritualized becomes what we worship. Whatever we make a practice out of becomes our object of worship.

Therefore, worship can best be defined as this:
The highest love and adoration that we experience and express towards someone or something.

One of the earliest Jesus followers, the Apostle Paul, wrote this about worship:

"Therefore, brothers and sisters, in view of the mercies of God, I urge you to present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and pleasing to God; this is your true worship." –Romans 12:1

Somewhere in our Church history, worship became about music. Although music is a powerful form that helps usher us into a state of worship, music isn't worship unto itself. Your life, everything you do and become, is an act of worship to God.

AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH

We have rituals at Garden City Church. We have an order to our services, a yearly calendar, and rhythms. However, our rituals point to our worship. Worship is one of Pastor Aaron's great passions as an author and songwriter. He understands that worship is not relegated to musicians but is a duty of all believers—a life before God that demonstrates obedience. Our worship is about our intent and our focus. In our services, our worship is extremely intentional. Our services are not about a production. Our lighting changes are minimal during service so we do not distract from worship. Furthermore, our lyrics, when we sing songs, are to minimize distractions. All of this is intentional.

Every time we gather, we also focus on God and not ourselves. It's not about us when it comes to worship. Everything we do points to God's majesty and glory. Each year, we have Worship Nights on October 31st, Christmas and New Years. These worship nights center our church. They help us to focus on the highest ideal of our church: God. We never want to lose focus on why we gather together. It's about celebrating what God has done in us and for us.

Christ is the only person we imitate. This helps guide our lives in two ways. One, there is something beyond us, a perfect holy being, leading us. Second, it helps us not make idols out of people. One of the biggest failures throughout Christianity is making idols out of pastors and leaders. Although we have leaders in Christian communities, they are not our object of worship. This helps us prevent disappointment, disillusionment, and false doctrines.

Prayer and Worship - Discussion

What does good communication look like in your relationships?

Is this something you can model with God through prayer? Why or why not?

What are your best times of focus during the week? How can you utilize those times for prayer and time with God?

What are some healthy and unhealthy rituals in your life? How can those rituals be a form of worship?

In your groups, take turns praying using the prayer model discussed earlier. In other words, pray by praising and thanking God, repenting, praying for one another, then praying for yourself.

ACTION ITEM

This week, be very intentional in how you pray and when you pray. Notice your weekly rituals. Pray with someone close to you (spouse, kids, parents, friends) this week and use the prayer model.

EXTRAS

The beauty of prayer is that Jesus followers have been praying for thousands of years. Some of these may be helpful for you as you pray.

- "We ask You, Master, to be our Helper and Protector. Save the afflicted among us; have mercy on the lowly; raise up the fallen; appear to the needy; heal the ungodly; restore the wanderers of Your people; feed the hungry; ransom our prisoners; raise up the sick; comfort the faint-hearted."–Clement of Rome, first century

- "Lord, be with us this day, Within us to purify us; Above us to draw us up; Beneath us to sustain us; Before us to lead us; Behind us to restrain us; Around us to protect us." –Patrick, c. 389-461

- "God, give me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change, the courage to change the things I can, and the wisdom to know the difference." –The Serenity Prayer

- "Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy upon me, a sinner." –The Jesus Prayer

- "Our Father in heaven, your name be honored as holy. Your kingdom come. Your will be done on earth as it is in heaven. Give us today our daily bread. And forgive us our debts, as we also have forgiven our debtors. And do not bring us into temptation, but deliver us from the evil one." –The Lord's Prayer

Week 2 - The Bible

INSPIRED WORD OF GOD

The Uniqueness of the Bible

The Bible is the most unique text in human history. Even those who don't follow Jesus cannot deny the unique position the Bible holds, though they may contest its merit. Nevertheless, it is a deeply spiritual text and is also accurate in its history. The Bible stands alone in that it is supported by historical precision and precedent.

The Purpose of the Bible

Though the Bible speaks to history, it is not a history book. Though it addresses science, it is not a book of science. The Bible is the story of God's relationship with creation and His plan of redemption. It provides answers to why we are here and what we are supposed to do about it.

As followers of Jesus, we believe the Bible is God's inspired Word, revealing Himself and our purpose. It guides us on relating to God, each other, handling finances, parenting, working, and dealing with our sexuality. Despite being written in a different time and culture, the Bible contains truths that transcend both. No matter who we are or where we come from, God's Word speaks truth to us and illuminates how we should live.

The Pure Message

When we say the Bible is "inerrant," we mean it does not affirm anything false. It teaches only truth and does not contradict itself. However, this does not mean the Bible is a science or history textbook. For example, when we talk to each other, our numbers can be accurate but imprecise. Comedian Mitch Hedberg once joked, "I heard MTV's Real World got 40,000 applications. That's incredible. Such an even number! You'd think it'd be 40,008, maybe." Similarly, biblical authors can be truthful without being exact. The feeding of the 5,000 men doesn't mean exactly 5,000 men were fed; it could have been 4,999 or 5,001.

What's important is that Jesus multiplied a small amount of food into enough for a huge crowd. We shouldn't get so lost in the details that we miss the point of a passage.

The Bible is a remarkable work of literature, written over hundreds of years by 40 different authors and compiled into 66 books. It contains various literary genres, such as allegorical stories, poetic narratives, prophetic messages, and historical eyewitness accounts. Despite its diversity, the Bible presents a unified picture of who God is and who we are in relation to Him. It tells the story of humanity's creation to rule over God's creation, our failure through rebellion, and God's plan to redeem us through the death and resurrection of His Son, culminating in a new creation.

Humanity's failure to rule on God's behalf, thinking we are gods ourselves, is a theme that starts in Genesis and runs throughout Scripture. God promised to redeem humanity through Israel (Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus). However, Israel failed in their quest to rule on God's behalf (Exodus, Judges, Samuel, Kings, Chronicles). Despite their failures, the Israelite prophets reminded the people of God's promise. The culmination of the biblical story is God the Son coming through Israel (Matthew, Mark, Luke, John). Jesus, fully God and fully man, restores the Genesis story. The entire Bible is woven into a cohesive narrative that provides practical hope, purpose, and direction.

This is why the New Testament narrative is so important. The Gospels are historical eyewitness accounts of God coming to earth. Early followers of Jesus saw Him, experienced Him, and recognized that the Old Testament promise had been fulfilled. Jesus' life, His love, and service exemplify how we should live. His death and resurrection allow us to live this way by conquering death and taking on humanity's sin. Through the power of God's Spirit, we can emulate Jesus, loving and serving humanity to the glory of God and for the redemption of all people.

THE WORD BECAME FLESH

In the early centuries, before the New Testament was compiled, the early disciples taught about the divinity of Jesus using the Old Testament. This is what makes the Bible so powerful and amazing. We are not simply looking at Jesus at the beginning of the New Testament; we see Him from the very beginning, in Genesis.

Jesus' disciple John writes: "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. He was with God in the beginning" (John 1:1-2). John was writing about Jesus here. God's Word was embodied in the person of Jesus. Therefore, everything Jesus said and did was directly from God. This is why Jesus and His immediate followers were able to start a movement years before the New Testament was ever written. They had the New (and Old) Testament living and breathing in front of them.

This is exactly why the biblical narrative of the New Testament is so important. The Gospels are historical eyewitness accounts that God came to earth. The key for the early Jesus followers was that they saw Jesus, they experienced Him in the flesh, and they understood that the Old Testament promise had been fulfilled. Jesus' life, the way He loved and served, shows us the perfect example of how we ought to live. His death and resurrection allowed humanity to live this way because He conquered death and took on humanity's sin. Through the power of God's Spirit, we can live out the picture of what we see in Jesus: loving and serving humanity to the glory of God and for the redemption of all people.

Thankfully, after Jesus ascended, His words and life were captured and inspired by God's Spirit. God's Word is our source, through His Spirit, to help us live as followers of Jesus.

INSPIRATION IS SHORTHAND...

"...[for] the belief that by his Spirit God guided the very different writers and editors, so that the books they produced were books God intended his people to have."

–N.T. Wright

THE GRAND NARRATIVE

The Bible has uniting themes from beginning to end, presenting a grand narrative about the love of God. Many people mistakenly believe there is a different God in the Old Testament than in the New Testament, but there is only one God. This misunderstanding arises from a lack of understanding of the Bible as a whole. The unifying theme of the Bible is that God created us out of love, intending for us to love in return. To truly love, we must have the freedom to choose it. However, with that freedom, humanity has repeatedly chosen sin.

The Bible illustrates God's love and His covenant to bring us back to Him despite our sin. This is the overarching narrative. Additionally, there are other major themes in Scripture that tie everything together. Below are some primary themes and points of focus that shape many of our practices and ways of living as followers of Jesus.

Image of God

As we will discuss in the section on the Trinity, being created in the image of God means we are designed for community (like the Trinity) and for love (mutual giving and receiving). This also means that everyone has significant value, regardless of who they are, which is why the Bible consistently emphasizes the importance of valuing life.

Covenant

God made a covenant (legal agreement) with His creation, intending for humanity to be in an intimate relationship with Him. From the Garden of Eden to the covenant with Abraham and ultimately to God coming to earth in Jesus, each step reflects the relationship God desires with us. Through this covenant we find hope and strength. Despite our shortcomings, God has promised to help us return to Him. His covenant is His commitment to being in a relationship with us.

Human Brokenness

We see throughout Scripture, no matter what God does to repair our relationship with Him, we mess that up—a lot! That hasn't changed much today, but it is clear in Scripture that humans are not perfect.

Sexuality

The Bible provides identity and parameters for human sexuality, presenting sex as a gift from God. He gave us sex to help us understand aspects of His nature. Although sex isn't the only way to understand God—Jesus Himself came as a celibate man—there are unique aspects of a God-ordained, marital, sexual relationship.

First, sex is intended to follow a covenant promise, namely marriage. The benefits of the sexual relationship are meant to exist only after this promise is established. Without the commitment of marriage, sex doesn't properly represent God.

Second, sex mirrors God's ability to create life through reproduction.

Finally, God-honoring sex centers on self-sacrificial love, involving mutual giving and receiving. This reflects how Jesus loved the church (His bride) and gave Himself for her. These themes, found in sex within a God-ordained marital relationship, are evident throughout the Old and New Testaments.

The Love of God

We've discussed God's love extensively, but it's worth reiterating its significance. God's love is the central theme of the Bible. However, love isn't merely about accepting people as they are; it also involves challenging them to become the absolute best their potential provides. This dual aspect of love is a consistent theme throughout Scripture. While the Bible emphasizes God's love, it also encourages its readers to grow, learn, and change significantly.

Justice

The Bible provides us with an understanding of God's justice, revealing His opposition to evil and sin. Particularly in the Old Testament, we witness a portrayal of God's fierce side, as His righteous anger is directed towards sin and its consequences. For example, while as Christians we do not believe that war is inherently condoned by God (as Jesus instructed to turn the other cheek, see Luke 6:26), we recognize the imperative to intervene and protect the innocent from harm or abuse. Throughout the entirety of the Bible, the theme of justice, opposing evil at all costs, is woven into its narrative.

“The Bible is very easy to understand. But we Christians are a bunch of scheming swindlers. We pretend to be unable to understand it because we know very well that the minute we understand, we are obliged to act accordingly.”
–Soren Kierkegaard

CONTEXT MATTERS

The most valuable insight you can gain about reading your Bible is the importance of understanding its context. We've all encountered instances where someone quotes a verse and applies it directly to their life, or attempts to challenge Christianity using a verse taken out of context. This practice is commonly referred to as "proof texting." It's essential to recognize that the Bible wasn't given to us for quick soundbites or to serve as simple inspirational phrases on our walls. Its depths cannot be fully grasped without considering its context.

When studying the Bible, avoid reading just one or two verses in isolation. Instead, read entire chapters and glance through the chapters before and after the one you're focusing on. Investigate the historical and cultural context of the book you're reading, and familiarize yourself with its author. Dedicate some extra time to understanding the broader narrative of the book. Never detach verses from their context while reading the Bible.

A beneficial approach is the inductive method, which entails gathering information before drawing conclusions. When reading Scripture, actively gather information by observing the text, understanding the characters, discerning the surrounding events, and considering how it fits within the broader narrative of the Bible. Then, based on your observations, begin to interpret the passage by asking why these events are occurring.

After carefully observing and interpreting Scripture, apply its teachings to your life. Application involves living out the Scripture's principles in your daily life. Unfortunately, many people read the Bible and hastily apply its teachings without first interpreting them within their context. This approach is flawed and undermines the true essence of engaging with the Word of God.

INDUCTIVE BIBLE STUDY

• **Observation:** What does this Scripture passage say? Simply observe the passage itself and its surrounding context, without adding personal opinions or external sources.

• **Interpretation:** Why is this passage saying what it does? Are there other passages that can help clarify its meaning? Is there a clear purpose for its inclusion here? After your own analysis, consult biblical commentaries for further insight. Talk to your Following Jesus coordinator for recommendations on helpful commentaries and other study resources.

• **Application:** How will I apply this passage in my life? What actions should I take based on its teachings?

Understanding the inductive method of biblical study is like having a good conversation with God. If your spouse asks you to do something important but you don't fully understand the request and its significance, you might end up making mistakes. This analogy resonates with us because we often do the same thing with God. We read a passage quickly and try to apply it without fully grasping its meaning and purpose. To faithfully follow Jesus, we need to communicate effectively with God.

For example, in Matthew 7:1, it says, *“Do not judge, so that you won’t be judged.”* Taken out of context, this one verse might lead us to immediately apply it by avoiding judgment of others. However, the true meaning of this passage becomes clearer when we consider the broader narrative of the passage and the entire biblical context.

The Bible

The entire chapter of Matthew 7 presents fascinating connections. Although the original Bible didn't have chapter and verse designations, it has been well-organized to follow the flow of inductive thought. In this chapter, we observe several key points. First, Jesus transitions from advising His followers not to judge to urging them to address their own sin before assessing others.

In essence, we must confront our own shortcomings before making judgments about others. This passage also provides guidance on how to do this. Firstly, through continuous prayer to God (verses 7-11), secondly, by treating others as we would like to be treated (verse 12), and by following the narrow path of God's Kingdom (verses 13-14). Then, Jesus indicates that we can discern people's character by observing how they live (verses 15-20). In other words, we are to judge people by the quality of their character. So, why would Jesus instruct us not to judge others? These observations suggest that we cannot make fair judgments if our hearts are not in the right place.

If we are not actively praying, obeying God's commands, and seeking His Kingdom, we cannot accurately judge others. The application of these insights then becomes clear. Are our hearts in the right place? Are we earnestly seeking God's Kingdom, devoting time to prayer, and striving to rid ourselves of unrighteousness? If not, we cannot make accurate judgments about others. Therefore, it is crucial for us to continually seek God's cleansing so that we can guide others back to Him. This understanding is far more profound than, "Only God can judge me."

STUDYING THE BIBLE AT GARDEN CITY

We Start with Scripture
During our weekend services, you'll notice a focus on Scripture. We read, observe, interpret, and apply it to our lives. Our messages revolve around the Bible. Every weekend, we carefully explore portions of the Bible, aiming to, in the words of Timothy Keller: *"Preach the Word, Preach the Gospel, Preach Christ from ALL Scripture, Preach Christ to culture, Preach Christ to the heart and 'let the Spirit preach.'"* [1]

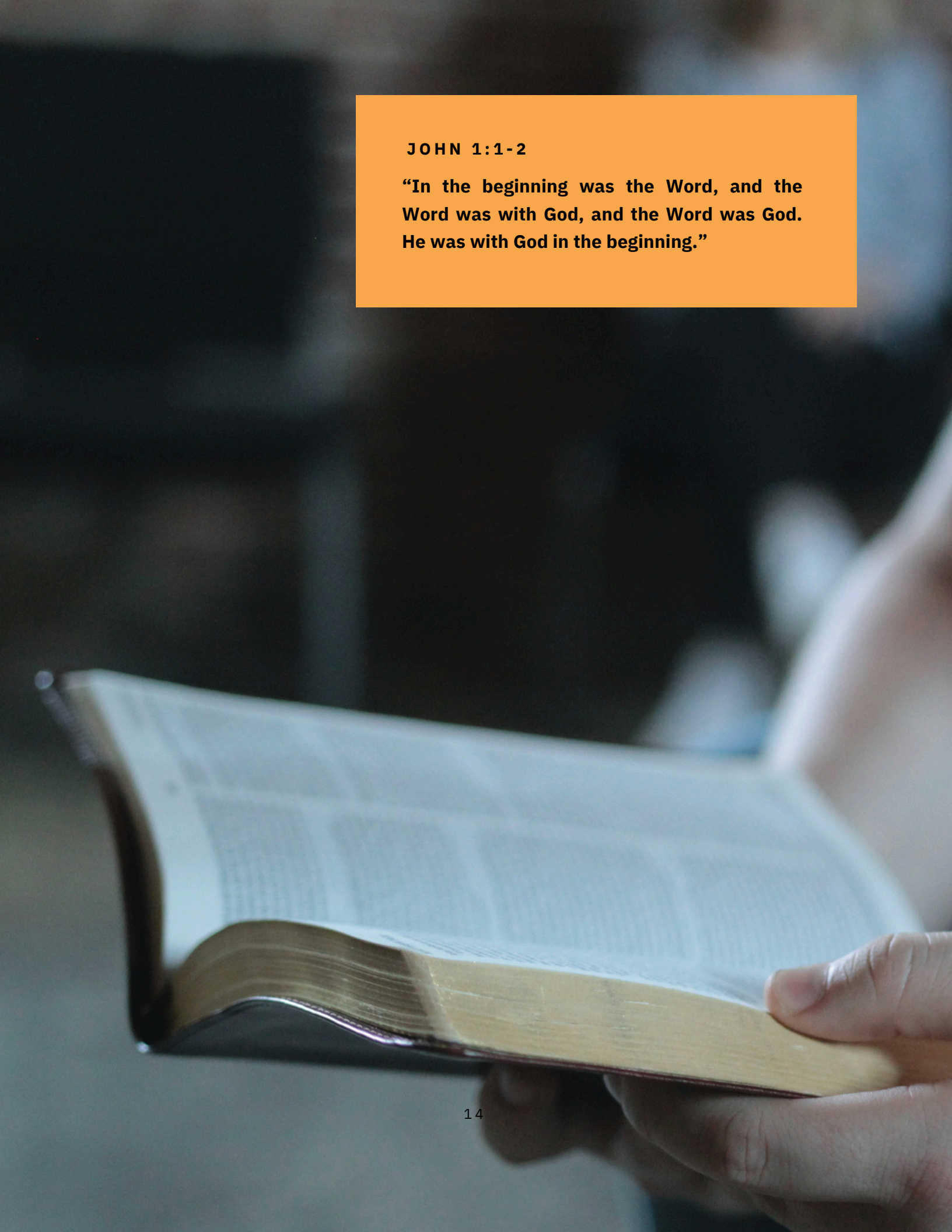
Garden City Church regards Scripture as our guiding book for all aspects of our faith and practice. However, while we believe all scripture is 'God breathed and true' we don't rigidly adhere to one interpretation of every scripture. While we uphold major doctrines, we don't engage in contentious debates over minor issues. We primarily use the NASB and NIV translations, but we welcome any version of the Bible you prefer. What matters most to us is that you are engaging with the Word of God.

[1] Keller, Timothy. *Preaching - Communicating Faith in an Age of Skepticism.* Viking Books, *2015.*

21-Day Fast
At the beginning of every year, we do a church-wide 21-day fast. This is a time of reflection to help our church focus on God and His Word. During that fast, we encourage a reading plan to help keep our church grounded in God's Word.

Our Daily Bread
We also emphasize the reading of God's Word every single day. You cannot follow Jesus if you don't know the words that are given to us. These practices are encouraged through reminders on our app and discipleship.

Bible Engagement Proect
A valuable resource for engaging with the Bible alongside others is the Bible Engagement Project. This initiative provides tools and resources to help both believers and non-believers explore the Bible for themselves in a meaningful way. You can find more information about the Bible Engagement Project at https://bibleengagementproject.com/.



JOHN 1:1-2

“In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. He was with God in the beginning.”

The Bible and the Holy Spirit

Garden City Church is unique in some ways compared to other Protestant and Evangelical Christian expressions, yet it shares many similarities with Charismatic and Pentecostal Christian expressions. The main difference lies in the language we use. At Garden City Church, we often use words like “prophetic,” “God says,” and “I sense in my heart.” These terms are common in Pentecostal circles and convey the belief that God speaks intimately to people in the present moment.

However, this belief comes with the risk of everyone having their own private experiences. How do we determine if such thoughts, feelings, or impressions are worth considering and true? The simple answer is God's Word. God's Word not only guides and directs us in how we ought to live and conduct ourselves in work, school, and community, but it also governs our own thoughts.

The Bible teaches us that our hearts are desperately wicked, which is a pre-conversion condition. After we are saved, we begin a journey of surrendering to the heart of God, and as a by-product, our hearts will become more like Christ’s. However, we are still flawed people, and we must ensure that we remain anchored in Scripture. This way, every feeling, thought, and impression—though potentially valuable—will not be exalted to a place that contradicts God’s Word or given too much credence, which could lead people astray.

BIBLICAL INTERPRETATION AND UNDERSTANDING

We Start With Scripture

At Garden City Church, our approach to studying the Bible primarily involves three activities, with expository preaching being the first. Expository preaching comes in various styles, but its core aim is to convey the Word without adding personal bias, while still making relevant connections to the present. Expository preaching entails explaining and applying the meaning of specific passages of Scripture, emphasizing understanding the text in its original context and then relating it to the lives of listeners.

Examples of Expository Preaching Include:

1. A sermon series on the Gospel of John, where each message explores a particular passage or theme within the Gospel, offering a detailed explanation and application of the text.
2. A sermon series on the Psalms, with each sermon analyzing a different Psalm, exploring its historical background, literary style, and theological significance.
3. A sermon focusing on a particular biblical narrative, such as the account of David and Goliath, where the preacher examines the passage verse by verse, drawing out its implications for faith and daily living.
4. A sermon series on a specific biblical theme or doctrine, such as the attributes of God or Christian discipleship principles, where relevant passages from Scripture are explored in an expository manner to provide deeper insight and understanding.

All aspects of ministering the Word rely on the Holy Spirit. Even drawing life-impacting themes and messages is possible, regardless of one's beliefs, through contextual reading. However, the second and third methods of preaching entail intentionally engaging with the Word through the Holy Spirit. These methods are defined as Logos and Rhema.

Logos and Rhema are two Greek terms used in biblical interpretation:

Logos refers to the written Word of God, encompassing the entirety of Scripture. It represents the divine, eternal Word of God that is recorded in the Bible.

Rhema on the other hand, refers to a specific, personalized word from God. It is a spoken word, often understood as a specific message or revelation from Scripture that applies directly to a particular situation or individual.

In the context of Bible reading, Rhema and Logos are categorized under the broader umbrella of biblical interpretation and understanding. They represent different aspects of engaging with the Word of God: Logos as the overarching message of Scripture, and Rhema as the personalized, spoken word of God.

The Bible - Discussion

What are some steps you can take to create more time to read the Bible?

What is a story in the Bible that has helped you or inspired you?

What are some of your questions about or struggles with the Bible?

Take a moment and have someone read John 13:1-17, and ask the following questions:

What are some things we observe (observation)?

Where do you see that in the passage?

Why would it say that (interpretation)?

What should we do about it, and how can we apply this (application)?

WHAT'S NEXT?

A great place to start reading is Luke, Acts, then Genesis. Luke and Acts give you the beginning of Jesus and His followers, while Genesis gives you the beginning of the biblical story.

ACTION ITEM

Read Luke 10 this week. Read it by observing it. Ask, what is it saying? Take time to understand the context. Then interpret what you have observed. Ask, why is it saying it? Finally, journal some simple applications to your life. Ask, what should I do because of what I read?

EXTRAS

At Garden City Church, we frequently emphasize that "the best version of the Bible is the one you will read." However, it's important to understand the different approaches to interpreting the Bible. There are three main categories of Bible translations:

1. Literal translations, which aim to translate each word from the original text as accurately as possible. Examples include the English Standard Version (ESV) and the New American Standard Bible (NASB).

2. Dynamic equivalence translations, which focus on conveying the overall meaning or thought of the original text rather than translating word-for-word. Examples include the New International Version (NIV) and the New Living Translation (NLT).

3. Paraphrased Bibles, which rephrase the text in modern language to make it easier to understand. Examples include The Message and The Living Bible.

Understanding these distinctions can help you choose a Bible translation that suits your preferences and needs.

- **Word-for-word Bibles,** such as the English Standard Version (ESV) and the New American Standard Bible (NASB), prioritize literal accuracy to the original languages. While they offer precise translations, they can be more challenging to read due to their literal approach.
- **Thought-for-thought Bibles,** like the New International Version (NIV) and the New Living Translation (NLT), aim to strike a balance between readability and accuracy. They convey the overall meaning of the original text while maintaining some level of literal accuracy.
- **Paraphrased Bibles,** such as The Message and The Living Bible, provide a rephrased version of Scripture in modern language. While they offer readability and insights, they sacrifice some accuracy in favor of easier comprehension.

RESOURCES

- One of the best resources for understanding the context of a book of the Bible is The Bible Project. They have incredible, digestible videos to help you grow. You can find their website here: thebibleproject.com or on their YouTube channel.
- Another simple resource is the YouVersion Bible app. They have reading plans as well as multiple versions of the Bible.
- A good summary of translations can be found here: http://www.biblereviewer.com/bible-translation-comparison/. We primarily use and recommend the CSB.

Week 3 - Baptism and Communion

Within the Christian faith, there's a spectrum of practices regarding baptism and communion. Some churches emphasize these acts as outward expressions of faith, while others rarely mention them. Traditionally, these practices are referred to as ordinances, a term we in the Assemblies of God prefer over "sacraments."

Here's why we make this distinction:

- Evangelical Focus on Faith: We emphasize the importance of personal faith in Jesus Christ for salvation. Ordinances, in our view, symbolize a believer's existing faith, not a means to earn it.
- Sacraments Often Imply Conferring Grace: The term "sacrament" can carry the idea that the act itself imparts God's grace. We believe grace is a free gift received solely through faith in Jesus.

Despite our preference for "ordinances," baptism and communion hold great significance for all believers. Let's explore what they represent.

BAPTISM

Baptism is a powerful tradition where someone is symbolically buried in water and then raised up again. It might seem like a unique act, but have you ever considered the deeper meaning behind the water? There is a deep biblical connection. Water has always been associated with God’s people and the act of God saving and helping His people through water.

Water: A Symbol of God's Deliverance

The Bible uses water repeatedly to illustrate God's power to save His people.

- The Red Sea Crossing (Exodus 14): Enslaved in Egypt, the Israelites were miraculously freed by God parting the Red Sea. Walking through the water on dry land symbolized their escape from oppression and their journey towards a new life.
- Sacrificial Washings (Numbers 19): In the Old Testament, animal sacrifices were offered for sin. Interestingly, these rituals involved water for purification, foreshadowing the cleansing power of Christ's sacrifice.
- Jesus' Baptism (Matthew 3:15): Even though sinless, Jesus submitted to baptism by John the Baptist. This act signified His identification with humanity and His role in fulfilling God's plan.

These water-related events point towards the ultimate act of salvation - Jesus' sacrifice on the cross. The cross, not the water itself, is the true source of our freedom. Just as the Israelites walked free through the Red Sea, Jesus' sacrifice allows us to be free from sin and death. We can call this the "New Exodus."

AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH

We believe baptism is a powerful outward expression of an inward decision. It's a public declaration of your faith in Jesus' sacrifice and the new life He offers. Imagine baptism as a beautiful symbol of being washed clean and starting fresh. Just as Jesus died and rose again, baptism signifies leaving behind your old life and embracing the hope found in Christ. As the Apostle Paul reminds us, "we were buried with him by baptism into death" (Romans 6:4). But at Garden City Church, baptism goes beyond personal transformation. It's a joyous entry into our church family, a community built on shared faith in Jesus. We believe church should be a family, a place where you belong no matter your background. Through baptism, you declare your commitment to this family and the larger family of God. Your identity is no longer defined by past failures, your job, or even your family of origin. In Christ, you are a beloved child of God, welcomed with open arms. Baptism is a celebration of this newfound identity and the incredible journey of faith ahead.

JESUS' DEATH AND RESURRECTION

Baptism begins and ends with Jesus' death and resurrection. Jesus' disciple, John, says it like this:

> *"Jesus Christ—he is the one who came by water and blood, not by water only, but by water and by blood. And the Spirit is the one who testifies, because the Spirit is the truth. For there are three that testify: the Spirit, the water, and the blood—and these three are in agreement." –1 John 5:6-8*

Jesus' baptism was a foreshadowing of the cross. It is in the cross that Jesus was baptized in blood, buried in a grave, and then rose from the dead. Baptism represents that very event in history.

Identifying with Jesus

Imagine a new beginning, a chance to wash away the past and step into a life renewed. That's the essence of baptism. It's a powerful symbol of our connection to Jesus' sacrifice on the cross. When Jesus died, it wasn't just the end of His earthly life. It was the ultimate act of love, a sacrifice for our sins. We are powerless to save ourselves, yet through Jesus' death and resurrection, freedom becomes possible. Baptism beautifully portrays this new life. Just as Jesus was buried and rose again, we are symbolically buried in the water and raised anew. As the Apostle Paul reminds us:

> *"You were also circumcised in him with a circumcision not done with hands, by putting off the body of flesh, in the circumcision of Christ, when you were buried with him in baptism, in which you were also raised with him through faith in the working of God, who raised him from the dead. And when you were dead in trespasses and in the uncircumcision of your flesh, he made you alive with him and forgave us all our trespasses."*
> *Colossians 2:11-13*

When we come to faith in Christ, and follow His example and command into baptism, we leave behind the "junk" of our old lives and embrace the hope offered by Jesus.

Church Family

But baptism isn't just about a personal transformation. It's also about joining a family. By being baptized, we declare our faith in Jesus and become part of a larger community, the Church. We are no longer alone in our journey of faith. As Galatians 3:26-29 tells us, "through faith you are all sons of God in Christ Jesus...There is no Jew or Greek, slave or free, male and female; since you are all one in Christ Jesus."

> *"...for through faith you are all sons of God in Christ Jesus. For those of you who were baptized into Christ have been clothed with Christ. There is no Jew or Greek, slave or free, male and female; since you are all one in Christ Jesus. And if you belong to Christ, then you are Abraham's seed, heirs according to the promise."*
> *Galatians 3:26-29*

Who can be baptized?

So, who can be baptized? Anyone who has repented of their sins and placed their faith in Jesus' work of salvation can take this step. Baptism is a public declaration of that faith, a celebration of the new life found in Christ, and a joyful entry into the family of God.

"...baptism draws together all those stories about creation and Exodus, about Jesus...When we baptize someone, we are participating in that same narrative. We are saying, we are on this journey, this is our story, and it is now your story as well. And if you stick with us, we will help you live that story with us. That's what baptism is all about." –N.T. Wright

DISCIPLESHIP'S RELATIONSHIP TO BAPTISM

The key to baptism is the commitment to discipleship, or, in our everyday language, a commitment to development with Jesus. Following Jesus means we are on a lifelong journey. Over and over we hear the Great Commission:

> *"Go, therefore, and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe everything I have commanded you..." –Matthew 28:19-20*

Probably the most overlooked part of the Great Commission is the part where, after baptism, it says to teach those who were baptized to observe all that Jesus commanded. That's a lot to learn and practice. How many of you can name all the commands of Jesus? Anyone? It's a lifelong process to develop. It's called being a learner, or a disciple of Jesus. This shouldn't scare us, but it should excite us! We get to grow daily with Jesus. Baptism isn't the end but a beginning component to our journey. We have many ways to continue to develop and grow. It starts in this group, but can continue in life, worship, personal growth classes, serving, and further intentional discipleship.

COMMUNION

Communion is one of the more overlooked elements of the Christian life. It is a sacred act that Jesus gave to us as His followers. Right before Jesus was going to be betrayed and given over for crucifixion, He shared the Passover meal with His disciples.

> *"Then He took a cup, and after giving thanks, He said, 'Take this and share it among yourselves. For I tell you, from now on I will not drink of the fruit of the vine until the kingdom of God comes.' And he took bread, gave thanks, broke it, gave it to them, and said, 'This is my body, which is given for you. Do this in remembrance of me.' In the same way he also took the cup after supper and said, 'This cup is the new covenant in my blood, which is poured out for you. God and His people—an agreement confirmed with my blood, which is poured out as a sacrifice for you.'" –Luke 22:17-20*

Communion represents the body that was broken on the cross and the blood that was shed. Christ is always present in our lives, and that is no different when we take communion. Jesus was present with His disciples at that first communion table, and His Spirit is still present with us every time we take communion.



EXAMINE YOURSELF

We are supposed to reflect and remember why Jesus died for us every time we take the bread (body) and juice (blood). He died to unite us back to God. Only those who have genuinely repented and are in a growing relationship with Jesus can take communion. This is not a dogmatic, religious rule, but a guideline that helps protect our souls and the sacredness of the act. The first time the disciples took communion with Jesus, it was an intimate, sacred experience. This is no different today. Reflection and repentance are key elements in communion.

Reflect and Remember

Typically, Christians understand communion (the Lord's Supper or the Eucharist) as the representation of Jesus' sacrifice on the cross; where His body was broken, and His blood was shed. Of course, this is a piece of what communion means, but it's not the only piece. There are three key elements of communion that we should remember and reflect on every time we take part in the act.

First, remember the past. Communion represents the historical event where Jesus died on a cross to conquer sin and death, thus defeating its power and reign over us. When we partake in communion we should think about Jesus' life. God came to earth in flesh. As we hold the elements, it's a reminder that an unknowable God became known. Most of all, we remember that Jesus was whipped and beaten, His body broken. And we remember that Jesus' blood was shed. This was all done so God could raise from the dead and show us He is King over all things, even death. Our trust and belief in Jesus as our King and our realization that we are not, helps us to live life as His followers. This is what we remember when we participate in communion.

Yet, it's not the only thing we must be reminded of when we partake in communion.

The second aspect of remembrance in communion is that we are being reminded that Jesus is present. Jesus told His first followers, "I will be with you always, even to the end of the age" (Matthew 28:20). Jesus is not some distant, historical figure from the days of the past. Jesus is alive and active in our lives.

Communion is a physical reminder that our God is with us. Through all of our struggles, joys, pain, and triumphs, God's Spirit is working in us and helping us as His followers.

We are living in the "already and not yet" days. This means Jesus is already here, His Kingdom has come, but it is not yet fully here. Jesus will return again physically some day and put an end to evil once and for all.

And that is the last thing we remember and reflect on as we take communion. Jesus is coming back as He promised in His Word. In Revelation, it says, "the marriage of the Lamb has come, and his bride has prepared herself" (Revelation 19:7). One day, as Jesus' faithful followers, we will dine around the table with our God. We will be able to intimately celebrate a meal with our Healer and Redeemer. There will be nothing like it. Communion is a reminder of this. It's a beautiful moment of anticipation and hope.

The Apostle Paul says,

> *"...whoever eats the bread or drinks the cup of the Lord in an unworthy manner will be guilty of sin against the body and blood of the Lord. Let a person examine himself; in this way let him eat the bread and drink from the cup. For whoever eats and drinks without recognizing the body, eats and drinks judgment on himself." – 1 Corinthians 11:27-29*

AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH,

we celebrate communion on the first Sunday of every month, which we call "Family Sunday." This is an open communion service, welcoming all believers in Christ to share in this special time, even if you don't attend Garden City regularly.

Baptism and Communion - Discussion

Have you watched a water baptism service here at Garden City Church, or elsewhere? What was that like?

Have you been baptized? What was your baptism experience like?

If you haven't been baptized, what stands in the way? If you haven't been baptized, but have committed to following Jesus (not the class), schedule it as soon as possible!

What is your plan to continue to learn and grow as a Jesus follower? Is it scary to think we are supposed to learn everything Jesus commanded after we are baptized?

We often reflect on Jesus' death at communion. What are some thoughts that can help you to remember that Jesus is always alive, active, and present with you? Is it helpful to know Jesus is always near? Why?

What are some steps you can take to examine your own soul before taking communion? What are some areas you can reflect on and questions you can ask yourself to help you examine?

ACTION ITEM

Be intentional the next time you take communion. Read Matthew 26:17-30. Note, particularly verses 24, 26, and 29. Jesus predicts His death, shows it's a physical reminder of His presence as the body and blood, and talks about the future banquet with His followers. Reflect on these three aspects before communion.

EXTRAS

Here are some of the primary commands we should know, practice, and help others understand as Jesus followers.

- Love God and people: Luke 10
- Make disciples and proclaim the gospel: Matthew 28:18-20; Luke 10
- Be humble and repent: Matthew 4:17; 18:21-22; Luke 14:7-11
- Discipleship components, following Jesus, take His yoke, and learn from Him: Matthew 4:19; 8:22, 11:29, 16:24; Mark 1:17; Luke 9:23; John 12:26, 21:19, 22
- Believe and have faith: Mark 5:36; 11:22-25; Luke 8:50; John 14:1, 11
- A Christian life: Matthew 5 (the Beatitudes)
- Don't fear: Matthew 14:27; 17:7; Mark 6:50; Luke 5:10
- Pray: Matthew 9:38; Luke 10:2; John 4:35; Matthew 26:41; Mark 14:38; Luke 11:2; John 16:24; Matthew 5:43-44
- Hear God's voice: Matthew 11:15; 13:9, 43; Mark 4:9, 23; Luke 8:8; 14:35
- Care for the poor: Matthew 19:21; Mark 10:21; Luke 14:12-14, 21, 23; 18:22
- Respect the government: Matthew 22:19-21; Mark 12:17; Luke 20:25

Week 4 - The Trinity and the Holy Spirit

WHAT IS THE TRINITY?

Many people spend their lives trying to understand who God is. Some speak of God as a concept, a distant being, or a mental invention. However, as followers of Jesus, we believe in a complex, powerful, and intimately personal God best understood through the Trinity, a concept often seen as complicated. God is not hidden but has positioned Himself so that people, as scripture tells us, "seek Him" (Acts 17:27). This mystery is revealed through Christ (Ephesians 1:9). While we are invited into intimacy with God, there remain aspects of His nature that are too marvelous to fully grasp and will always be beyond our comprehension.

St. Augustine of Hippo said, “If you can fully grasp it, it’s not God.” Indeed, God is a complicated being. However, if we are to serve and love Him, we should strive for a basic understanding of who God is. Therefore, reflecting on the Christian understanding of the Trinity is essential.

God is One and Three

To understand God as one perfect, holy being who exists in three persons—the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit—we must delve into the doctrine of the Trinity. Though each person of the Trinity is distinct, they share the same essence and being. The Bible clearly reveals God in three persons, when we see the term "persons," it can be understood as distinct personalities.

John 1:1-5 distinguishes between the Word, who exists with God and is God. In John 10:30, Jesus states that He and the Father are one. In Genesis 1:26, God speaks in the plural as Creator. At the baptism of Jesus, we witness the Holy Spirit descending, the voice of God speaking, and Jesus in physical form. These instances and others throughout scripture demonstrate the distinctiveness within the unity of God.

2 Corinthians 13:14 encapsulates this beautifully: "The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and the love of God and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all."

Each person of the Trinity is distinct yet part of the same being. An analogy can help illustrate this concept. Consider the human body, which is unified but composed of distinct parts, such as the head and the feet. The foot, while distinct, is not independent from the head. The head, which houses the brain, commands the foot. Similarly, the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are distinct yet inseparable, each playing a unique role within the unity of one God.

The Mystery

If we could fully understand God entirely, He wouldn’t be God. The concept of the Trinity might not make complete sense, because God Himself transcends human understanding. Sometimes, faith involves believing despite not having all the answers. God remains a mystery, and we are growing and learning progressively. Jesus is God in visible form.

Colossians 1:5 says “He is the image of the invisible God, the firstborn of all creation.”

This is why following Jesus is so central to our faith; God became flesh and blood like us so that we could know Him better. But our understanding still has limitations.
Some accuse Jesus' followers of using "mystery" as an excuse when something seems illogical. However, it is logical to acknowledge that the mind of God is far beyond our own. We simply cannot understand everything about Him. It’s like an insect trying to comprehend a human being—it’s an impossible task. Just as an insect cannot grasp human nature and relationships, so too is the mind of God infinitely beyond our comprehension.

“Bring me a worm that can comprehend a man, and then I will show you a man that can comprehend the Triune God.” –John Wesley

AN EXPRESSION OF GOD'S LOVE

An Illustration

We often rely on illustrations to understand God because His fullness is beyond our comprehension. This is evident when we realize that the Bible does not provide an explicit doctrine of the Trinity. Instead, as Alister McGrath notes, the Bible "bears witness to a God who demands to be understood in a trinitarian manner." In other words, the evidence of the Trinity is found in the way God works throughout the Bible.

God moves through His Spirit, and Jesus is God's Word made flesh on earth, fully God and fully man. The Father is the head directing the action. Though God is incomprehensible, we can understand and even personally know Him through Jesus and through observing God's work throughout Scripture.

We need illustrations and explanations because aspects of God remain a mystery. Yet, these tools help us grasp what we can of His divine nature and actions.

In Genesis it says,

> *"Then God said, 'Let us make man in our image, according to our likeness'...So God created man in his own image; he created him in the image of God; he created them male and female." –Genesis 1:26-27*

The Creation story reveals two key truths. First, God (three in one) created us. Second, we are a reflection of God. If you take nothing else away, understand that the Trinity embodies the community and love we are meant to reflect. God is love, and He exists in a community within Himself. This means there is an eternal exchange of love within the Trinity: the Father gives to the Son, the Son to the Spirit, and the Spirit to the Father, continuing for eternity. St. Augustine says, "Wherever there is love, there is a trinity: a lover, a beloved, and a fountain of love."

Being created in the image of God means we are meant to live in community and to love one another. The Holy Spirit is the expression of God's love and enables us to love.

Fruit of the Spirit

Here is the most practical aspect of surrendering to God's Spirit: the fruit of the Spirit. The apostle Paul, a follower of Jesus, says this:

> *"But the fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. The law is not against such things."*
> *–Galatians 5:22-23*

All of Him

When we accept Jesus as our Savior, how much of the Holy Spirit do we receive? We get all of Him. However, the more we surrender to God's Spirit, the more we become like Jesus. We allow God's Spirit to work in us through means of grace, such as Scripture, confession, prayer, community, worship, and reflection on Christ.

Creating Change in Us

The more we open ourselves to God's Spirit, the more His fruit will be evident in our lives. We become more loving, even towards the difficult people in our lives. We experience greater joy, regardless of our circumstances, and find peace amidst the chaos of the world. Patience becomes our companion in challenging situations, tense moments, and even during times of irritability. Kindness and goodness overflow from us, both at work and at home. We become more faithful in our commitments. Additionally, gentleness characterizes our interactions with others.

God's Spirit equips us with self-control, which proves invaluable in various aspects of life, such as managing our consumption habits and resisting sin. As we allow God's Spirit to work within us, He helps us govern our thoughts and actions. It's through the transforming power of His Spirit that we are changed, transformed and renewed. Ultimately, it is through the indwelling of God's Spirit that we participate in bringing His Kingdom on earth as it is in Heaven.

AN EXPRESSION OF GOD'S LOVE

BETTER UNDERSTANDING & DANGERS

Oneness theology, also known as *modalism* or *Sabellianism*, teaches that God exists in one mode or manifestation rather than three distinct persons of the Trinity. According to this view, God reveals Himself in different modes or roles at different times, such as Father in creation, Son in redemption, and Holy Spirit in sanctification. However, modalism denies the eternal coexistence of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit as distinct persons.

Evangelicals reject both Oneness theology and modalism because they are considered heretical and contradict orthodox Christian beliefs about the Trinity. The inherent danger of these beliefs lies in their distortion of the nature of God, leading to a misunderstanding of the fundamental truths of the Christian faith.

Scripture clearly presents the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit as distinct persons within the Godhead, each with unique roles and attributes. For example:

- **The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are distinct persons:**

Matthew 3:16-17 (NIV): "As soon as Jesus was baptized, he went up out of the water. At that moment heaven was opened, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove and alighting on him. And a voice from heaven said, 'This is my Son, whom I love; with him I am well pleased.'"

John 14:26 (NIV): "But the Advocate, the Holy Spirit, whom the Father will send in my name, will teach you all things and will remind you of everything I have said to you."

- **The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit interact with each other:**

Matthew 28:19 (NIV): "Therefore go and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit."

John 17:1-5 (NIV): Jesus prays to the Father, asking Him to glorify Him with the glory He had before the world began.

- **The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are co-eternal and co-equal:**

John 1:1-3 (NIV): "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. He was with God in the beginning. Through him all things were made; without him nothing was made that has been made."

1 Corinthians 12:4-6 (NIV): "There are different kinds of gifts, but the same Spirit distributes them. There are different kinds of service, but the same Lord. There are different kinds of working, but in all of them and in everyone it is the same God at work."

By denying the Trinity and the distinctiveness of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit, Oneness theology and modalism undermine the biblical revelation of God and jeopardize the foundation of Christian faith. Therefore, evangelicals reject these beliefs as contrary to Scripture and essential Christian doctrine.

A SIMPLE, NOT-SO-SIMPLE EXPLANATION

Explaining the Trinity can be challenging, but here's a simplified analogy: think of an apple. It's one "what" (an apple), but it has zero "who's" (no personhood). Now, consider a person: they're one "who" (an individual) and one "what" (a person). Now, God is different: He's three "who's" (Father, Son, Holy Spirit) and one "what" (God). While this analogy isn't perfect and may seem like multiple personalities, it helps grasp the idea of God's tri-personhood while being one indivisible being, as revealed in Scripture. It's not a perfect comparison, but it's a helpful way to understand the concept.

The Trinity and the Holy Spirit

GIFTS OF THE SPIRIT

Paul also instructed early Christians concerning the gifts of the Spirit. While the fruit of the Spirit facilitates the manifestation of Heaven on earth, bringing the Church's influence to the world, the gifts of the Spirit enable the Church to advance God's Kingdom from within. Paul articulates this in his letter:

The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit interact with each other**

> *"Now there are different gifts, but the same Spirit. There are different ministries, but the same Lord. And there are different activities, but the same God works all of them in each person. A manifestation of the Spirit is given to each person for the common good: to one is given a message of wisdom through the Spirit, to another, a message of knowledge by the same Spirit, to another, faith by the same Spirit, to another, gifts of healing by the one Spirit, to another, the performing of miracles, to another, prophecy, to another, distinguishing between spirits, to another, different kinds of tongues, to another, interpretation of tongues. One and the same Spirit is active in all these, distributing to each person as he wills." –1 Corinthians 12:4-11*

These gifts edify, empower, and conform the Church more closely to the likeness of Jesus. Hence, specific roles are designated within the church. Paul continues:

> *"God has appointed these in the church: first apostles, second prophets, third teachers, next miracles, then gifts of healing, helping, leading, various kinds of tongues." –1 Corinthians 12:28*

There are individuals particularly gifted to teach, assist, lead, heal, or deliver God's truth. Yet, akin to the Trinity itself, the Church must operate in unity with the Holy Spirit to ensure these gifts and roles are employed with order and prudence. Just as God crafted the universe with order and harmony, and His creation brought forth life, so too will the gifts of the Spirit be discernible by their orderly and life-giving application.

FINALLY

We believe that the Holy Spirit guides us in living out our Christian faith personally. Scripture clearly identifies activities such as drug use as sinful (1 Peter 4:3; Galatians 5:19-21; Romans 13:13). However, the personal conviction to abstain comes under the guidance of the Holy Spirit, who brings the command to life within our conscience. Similarly, Scripture warns against greed and the love of money as evil (Ecclesiastes 5:10; Luke 12:15). Yet, discerning what constitutes excessive wealth or how to allocate financial resources, as well as distinguishing between legitimate medical prescriptions as opposed to satisfying an urge or addiction through recreational or illicit substance use, involves the Holy Spirit's intervention and guidance as well as strictly adhering to the written word, as at times our consciences might be dull or unresponsive.

When faced with such questions, we follow a threefold process. First, we immerse ourselves in Scripture, allowing the Holy Spirit to illuminate relevant passages. Second, we consider the historical perspectives of the Church on these matters. Finally, we rely on personal conviction, guided by the Holy Spirit. The more we surrender to the Spirit's leading, the more He will shape and direct our decisions.

THE PENTECOSTAL PERSPECTIVE

What is Pentecostalism?

Pentecostalism is a vibrant and dynamic branch of Christianity characterized by an emphasis on the personal experience of the Holy Spirit. Believers seek to encounter the Spirit's power through experiences such as Spirit baptism, evidenced by speaking in tongues, and the operation of spiritual gifts. Pentecostals prioritize passionate worship, fervent prayer, and a commitment to spreading the gospel with signs and wonders. Their faith is marked by a deep reliance on the Holy Spirit for spiritual empowerment, leading to a vibrant expression of Christianity focused on personal transformation, community, and evangelism.

Why are some not Pentecostal?

The diversity within Christianity allows for a variety of beliefs and practices, and individuals may align themselves with a particular Christian tradition based on a combination of theological, cultural, and personal factors without compromising matters of salvation. Some of the reasons individuals might avoid Pentecostalism are as follows:

Theological Differences:

Not all Christians interpret Scripture in the same way, and theological differences can lead to varying beliefs about the Holy Spirit, spiritual gifts, and the nature of the Christian experience. Some Christians may hold different perspectives on topics such as Spirit baptism, speaking in tongues, and the operation of spiritual gifts.

Personal Preference:

Some individuals may simply prefer the worship style, liturgy, or theological emphasis of a non-Pentecostal tradition. They may feel more spiritually fulfilled or connected to God in a different worship setting.

Historical and Cultural Backgrounds:

Different denominations and Christian traditions have unique historical and cultural backgrounds that shape their beliefs and practices. Some Christians may come from traditions that do not emphasize Pentecostal theology or practices.

Lack of Exposure:

Pentecostalism may not be as prevalent in certain regions or communities, so individuals may not have been exposed to Pentecostal theology or practices.

Concerns or Misunderstandings:

Some Christians may have concerns or misunderstandings about Pentecostal practices, such as speaking in tongues or the emphasis on emotional expression in worship. These concerns may lead them to choose a different Christian tradition.

AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH

Pentecostalism places a significant emphasis on the baptism of the Holy Spirit. While we believe that all believers should experience this baptism with the initial evidence of speaking in tongues, we also strive to avoid division on this matter. Our approach is twofold. First, we do not restrict or suppress the Holy Spirit's expression in prayer or demonstration. This means we encourage and actively engage in the use of spiritual gifts, including prophecy, praying in diverse languages with interpretation, laying hands on the sick, and eagerly anticipating the Holy Spirit's movement. Second, for those unfamiliar with this style of worship, we never coerce or pressure anyone. However, we strongly encourage all individuals to maintain an open posture to the Lord, willing to receive whatever God desires to bestow upon them. In doing so, we remain open, respectful, and authentic. It's important to note that one does not need to be baptized in the Holy Spirit to be part of our community, but we value this experience and believe it is beneficial for all. For further understanding, we invite you to consider joining our Holy Spirit Class.

For more information - consider taking our Holy Spirit Class

The Trinity and the Holy Spirit - Discussion

The fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. Out of this list, where are you strongest and where do you need the most help?

If God is a community within Himself, and we reflect the image of God, how can we do better about building community and relationships (with our family, neighbors, fellow Jesus followers)?

What are some unhealthy images you have had of God? How can they be reframed?

Read Acts 1:8 aloud. Have you ever personally witnessed the power of God in operation? How did that make you feel?

What does surrender to God's Spirit look like for you daily?

ACTION ITEM

Write out the fruit of the Spirit listed in Galatians 5. Ask God in prayer to help you where you need His help. Ask Him to strengthen you. Be specific as you journal and pray.

EXTRAS

The Apostles' Creed is one of the most foundational pieces of doctrine in Christianity. It is a universally accepted creed among all forms of Christian belief and is believed to date back to the first century:

I believe in God, the Father almighty, creator of heaven and earth. I believe in Jesus Christ, His only Son, our Lord, who was conceived by the Holy Spirit and born of the virgin Mary. He suffered under Pontius Pilate, was crucified, died, and was buried; he descended to hell.The third day He rose again from the dead.He ascended to heaven and is seated at the right hand of God the Father almighty. From there He will come to judge the living and the dead. I believe in the Holy Spirit, the holy catholic* church, the communion of saints, the forgiveness of sins, the resurrection of the body, and the life everlasting. Amen.

*that is, the true Christian church of all times and all places

Week 5 - The Church

THE PAST AND THE PRESENT

When we talk about the Church, we must clarify exactly what we mean. Garden City Church is a church, yes, but when we say the Church, we mean every community that follows and loves Jesus and actively works to bring people back to Him. The Church is a global movement. This is why we partner with and support other churches and movements around our city, country, and world. Although Garden City Church has been around since 2009, the global Church, that is, the gathering of Jesus followers, has been around for nearly 2000 years! Our church exists because of martyrs, saints, and believers who have gathered for centuries. Christianity has a deep and rich tradition that we see born in the book of Acts after Jesus' resurrection from the dead and ascension to Heaven.

Witnesses

As mentioned in the section on the Bible, the first few centuries of Christianity lacked a physical copy of the New Testament as we have it today. The main authority and reason for growth came through the apostles of Jesus. The first Apostles where those who saw Jesus and were commissioned or 'sent' by him to deliver this message, establish churches and encourage believers. This is significant because it lends credibility to the early Church's movement. It wasn't based on one man's divine revelation that no one else could verify, but rather a collection of people who formed a church based on what they actually witnessed here on earth.

Paul wrote this to the ancient church in Corinth:

> "*For I passed on to you as most important what I also received: that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures, that He was buried, that He was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures, and that He appeared to Cephas, then to the Twelve. Then He appeared to over five hundred brothers and sisters at one time; most of them are still alive, but some have fallen asleep. Then He appeared to James, then to all the apostles. Last of all, as to one born at the wrong time, He also appeared to me."*
> *1 Corinthians 15:3-8*

The Three Doctrines

The early Church established fundamental doctrines and writings that contributed to its growth. From the outset, there was an orthodoxy, or unity, of belief within Christianity. Shortly after Jesus' death, resurrection, and ascension, three core doctrines were formalized:

1. Jesus of Nazareth is the Messiah.
2. He was crucified, rose from the dead, and is now living.
3. He ascended to Heaven and will return to earth to reign over His Church.

Thriving in the Fire

One of the most fascinating aspects of the early Church is that it faced extreme persecution for nearly 300 years. Christianity began in the Roman Empire and was not a welcomed movement. Christians were relentlessly beaten and scrutinized. In fact, in 64 AD, Emperor Nero sought to all but end Christianity.

The first-century Roman historian Tacitus wrote this about the first Christians:

"Besides being put to death they were made to serve as objects of amusement; they were clothed in the hides of beasts and torn to death by dogs; others were crucified, others set on fire to serve to illuminate the night when daylight failed away" (Tacitus, 60-120 AD).

The fact that the Church formed and grew under these conditions is a true work of God. For hundreds of years, the Church was an organic yet structured movement, influencing society from the bottom up. Eventually, society took notice. In 313 AD, the Roman Emperor Constantine adopted Christianity as the official religion of Rome. This marked the point when Christianity shifted into a more institutionalized movement. Institutions are not inherently bad, but they create power dynamics and struggles for control. As leaders sought power, divisions occurred, new movements formed, and today there are nearly 33,000 Christian denominations.

AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH

Our focus is on the original Church's passion: Jesus. As we often say, "we major on the majors, and minor on the minors." We aim to be an organic, organized movement that influences society, rather than an institution seeking attention and power.

A Place or a People?

Scripture describes the Church as both a place and a people. The Apostle Paul, in his missions and letters, mentions specific church locations. However, Scripture also portrays the Church as a people, emphasizing its fundamental image as the body of Jesus.

The Church is Alive

It is vital to remember that the Church is a living, breathing organism—Jesus' bride. It's not merely a building, a pastor, or a church staff. If you are a follower of Jesus, you are part of the Church!

Little Christs

Jesus is present in and through His followers. As Dietrich Bonhoeffer puts it when discussing confession:

> *"Who can give us the certainty that, in confession and the forgiveness of our sins, we are not dealing with ourselves but the loving God? God gives us this certainty through our brother. Our brother breaks the circle of self-deception. A man who confesses His sins in the presence of a brother knows that he is no longer alone with himself; he experienced the presence of God in the reality of the other person."*

We are Christ-bearers, or "little Christs." This should be both encouraging and sobering. Following Jesus profoundly affects those around you, and the way you live carries eternal significance.

The Hope of the World

Therefore, when we look around the world and see the brokenness, hurt, destruction, sin, and pain, we are actually responsible for doing something about it. Andy Stanley says:

> *"Jesus is the hope of the world and the local church is the vehicle of expressing that hope to the world."*

We should not rely on the government or any particular politician to change our world. The Church is supposed to be the change agent. Whether it is homelessness, the devaluing of life, addiction, or poverty, we should not be complaining, but actively involved in the transformation.

What Can I Do?

As we learned in the section on prayer, Jesus taught us to pray, "Your Kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in Heaven." The Church is responsible for helping to bring Heaven to earth. Therefore, we must actively be the Church! This means getting involved in making a difference.

Serving in your church should never be about merely "filling a role" or performing "community service." It's about transforming the world around you and bringing in God's Kingdom. Everything you do, whether inside the church building or out in the community, has an impact. Find a way to serve in your context and be the Church!

The Church

OUR MISSION, VISION, AND PROCESS AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH

At our church, we have a clear mission, vision, and process for how we impact the world through Christ.

MISSION

To know Christ and make Him known in our city and in every nation.

Many people claim to be "Christian" but do very little to show it. Jesus said we will know His followers by their fruit, meaning by the way they live and love. We seek authentic followers who are making an impact around them, not just more cultural Christians. Our mission is to know Christ and make Him known in our city and in every nation.

VISION

Live the Life.
Tell the Story.

Our services center on God and His Word, emphasizing authenticity over production. We foster a genuine community where people are embraced as they are. With pure hearts, we actively serve our city, nation, and world. Our passion is to transform the world through living the life and telling the Story of Christ!

PROCESS

Worship, Learn, Love, Lead

Our process is designed to empower individuals to make a significant impact. Each component includes multiple ministries. We emphasize that authentic followers are continuously engaged in community, growth, and service.



IMPORTANT CHURCH PRACTICES

Serving

Jesus demonstrated the essence of serving one another by washing His disciples' feet. John, one of those disciples, recorded this profound moment:

"When Jesus had washed their feet and put on His outer clothing, he reclined again and said to them, 'Do you know what I have done for you? You call me Teacher and Lord—and you are speaking rightly, since that is what I am. So if I, your Lord and Teacher, have washed your feet, you also ought to wash one another's feet. For I have given you an example, that you also should do just as I have done for you.'" – John 13:12-15

Being the Church requires us to serve one another. This can mean welcoming someone at the door or leading a group. Each person is called to emulate Jesus' example of serving others within the church community.

Prayer and Confession

Prayer is not merely an individual practice; it should be an integral part of our corporate worship. At our church, we emphasize this by gathering for daily morning prayer and hosting prayer sessions on Tuesday evenings.

This practice aligns with the command of James, Jesus' brother:

"*Confess your sins to one another and pray for one another, so that you may be healed." – James 5:16*

Our church is a place where we can openly confess our sins, knowing we will receive help and healing. God values our humble confession and promises not to turn us away, except for those who persist in arrogant sin without repentance. Our pastor and intercessors are available each week following services to pray with anyone seeking prayer.

Tithes and Offerings

Together, as we pursue God's mission, we aim to nurture both a generous and faithful community. Tithing involves giving 10% of our income to support the local church community we attend, while offerings are contributions beyond the tithe directed towards our church or other Kingdom-advancing causes. At Garden City Church, these financial contributions support ministry work, outreach efforts, mission endeavors, and benevolence initiatives.

The book of Acts provides a model for how the church should approach giving:

> *"All the believers were together and held all things in common. They sold their possessions and property and distributed the proceeds to all, as any had need. Every day they devoted themselves to meeting together in the temple, and broke bread from house to house. They ate their food with joyful and sincere hearts..."*
> *– Acts 2:44-46*

COLOSSIANS 3:16

"Let the word of Christ dwell richly among you, in all wisdom teaching and admonishing one another through psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs, singing to God with gratitude in your hearts."

The Church - Discussion

How has Garden City Church helped you grow, or how has it challenged you?

What are some things you have noticed in our world that are broken? How do you think we can help as the church?

Are you serving? If you serve at Garden City talk about what that is like. If you don't, what's gotten in the way?

Why is confession (admitting our sins to another person) so hard?

What are some positive and negative thoughts around giving to the church?

ACTION ITEM

The best way for you to be the church is to be a part of the church community. This week's action item is about two parts.

1. Definitively signing up for a ministry within the church (if you aren't already). Sign up, and we will contact you with the next steps for involvement in that ministry.
2. Start to determine if people in your group would be willing to host fellowships or bible studies.

EXTRAS

"We believe in one God, the Father almighty, maker of heaven and earth, of all things visible and invisible.

And in one Lord Jesus Christ, the only Son of God, begotten from the Father before all ages, God from God, Light from Light, true God from true God, begotten, not made; of the same essence as the Father. Through him all things were made. For us and for our salvation he came down from heaven; he became incarnate by the Holy Spirit and the virgin Mary, and was made human. He was crucified for us under Pontius Pilate; he suffered and was buried. The third day he rose again, according to the Scriptures. He ascended to heaven and is seated at the right hand of the Father. He will come again with glory to judge the living and the dead. His kingdom will never end.

And we believe in the Holy Spirit, the Lord, the giver of life. Who proceeds from the Father, Who with the Father and the Son together is worshiped and glorified. He spoke through the prophets. We believe in one holy catholic and apostolic church. We affirm one baptism for the forgiveness of sins. We look forward to the resurrection of the dead, and to life in the world to come. Amen."

Week 6 - Sharing Your Faith

PROSELYTIZING VS. SHARING

Sharing Your Faith

Many times, sharing your faith can be confused with proselytizing. Proselytizing is the attempt to convert someone to your way of thinking without taking the time to build a relationship. It involves aggressively trying to change another's religion or belief system without truly knowing them. Have you ever had someone knock on your door and begin describing their religious mindset without considering what's going on in your life or what you think? This approach often feels rehearsed and impersonal.

Sharing your faith, on the other hand, is about building relationships and fostering genuine connections. When sharing your faith as a follower of Jesus, the focus should be on transformation rather than merely transferring information. Our mission is to share the faith we have, because God has entrusted us to bring people back to Him. Paul emphasizes this in Romans 10:13-15:

"For everyone who calls on the name of the Lord will be saved. How, then, can they call on him they have not believed in? And how can they believe without hearing about him? And how can they hear without a preacher? And how can they preach unless they are sent? As it is written: How beautiful are the feet of those who bring good news."

Evangelism

Evangelizing, distinct from both proselytizing and sharing, is the scriptural mandate to proclaim the gospel and make disciples of all nations. Evangelism involves clearly communicating the message of Jesus Christ with the intent of leading others to faith, as exemplified by the Great Commission (Matthew 28:19-20). It's about delivering the good news with both love and urgency, respecting the listener's freedom to choose. A key difference between general proselytizing and true evangelism is the leading and empowerment of the Holy Spirit. The Bible clearly portrays evangelism as a gift and an office within the church. This ministry is not about being a casual witness or driven by self-ambition; it is the Spirit of God compelling His people to witness in a distinct and powerful way.

Building Authentic Credibility

We build credibility through relationships. It's often said that people don't care how much you know unless they know how much you care. Demonstrating care for others before sharing what we know is crucial. Part of the gospel is about the God of the universe coming to earth to meet His creation where they are. God limited Himself so that we could intimately know Him.

Following God's example, we need to meet people where they are and build relationships. This involves getting to know people, their families, and their passions. We also build credibility through our actions. While we don't need to be perfect, we should strive to be good examples of living and reacting in a Christ-like manner. When we make mistakes, we should quickly own them and seek reconciliation. How we repair and restore connections speaks volumes about the Jesus we serve.

Finally, we build credibility through communicating our story and God's story. Sharing how we found our way to God and what it means to us is vital. It could be as simple as saying, "I started going to church, and it's helped me to have more passion and clarity." Or it could involve sharing a more complex journey, such as overcoming a drug addiction through faith. Understanding Scripture and how God has redeemed humanity through Jesus Christ allows us to effectively share God's story with others.

To delve deeper into what it means to evangelize and how to effectively share your faith, join the upcoming evangelism class at Garden City Church. This class will provide you with the tools and knowledge needed to fulfill the Great Commission and bring others to Christ in a loving and impactful way.

Not only do we need to build credibility, but as followers of Jesus, we must be intentional about sharing our faith. This often means building long-term relationships, taking the time to get to know people, and investing in them over time. However, we may also encounter spontaneous opportunities to talk about Jesus. When we pray for these moments and sense the Holy Spirit confirming them, we should share our faith in a loving and genuine way.

This doesn't mean we have to be perfect. We are still human and in need of God's Spirit. When we are intentional, we must also be willing to reconcile. If we make a mistake, we should apologize. If we are not kind or patient, we should ask for forgiveness. Reconciling is one of the most powerful ways to share your faith. It shows that Christians aren't perfect but are striving to be more like Jesus. Intentionality is at the heart of how Jesus intended us to live as His followers. Matthew recorded Jesus telling His followers to share their faith:

> *"Look, I'm sending you out like sheep among wolves. Therefore be as shrewd as serpents and as innocent as doves. Beware of them, because they will hand you over to local courts and flog you in their synagogues. You will even be brought before governors and kings because of me, to bear witness to them and to the Gentiles. But when they hand you over, don't worry about how or what you are to speak. For you will be given what to say at that hour, because it isn't you speaking, but the Spirit of your Father is speaking through you." –Matthew 10:16-20*

Be Shrewd But Pure

Being shrewd means being intentional and clever about how we share our faith. It involves discerning the right moments to speak up about our beliefs and knowing when to hold back. It also means seizing opportunities to share our faith whenever they arise.

However, we must also be as innocent as doves. This means having pure intentions without ulterior motives or manipulative tactics. Our approach in sharing faith should be genuine and sincere, reflecting the love and truth of Jesus Christ.

When Do I Share?

Sometimes it's hard to know with whom we should share our faith. We need the Holy Spirit's help in discerning this. A good rule of thumb is to share with what some call "people of peace." These are individuals who are willing and open to engaging in spiritual conversations. This concept comes from Scripture, where Jesus instructs His followers to minister to receptive and welcoming people:

> *"Whatever house you enter, first say, 'Peace to this household.' If a person of peace is there, your peace will rest on him; but if not, it will return to you. Remain in the same house, eating and drinking what they offer, for the worker is worthy of his wages. Don't move from house to house." – Luke10:5-7*

Some examples from Scripture of "people of peace" are Zacchaeus and the woman at the well with whom Jesus interacted. An easy way to identify and remember the "people of peace" is to think of people as red, yellow, or green lights for how receptive they are to hearing about following Jesus. They can be described in these ways:

- **Red light:** Not receptive, maybe even hostile toward any mention of God.
- **Yellow light:** Curious, open, but not too sure about what you have to say spiritually.
- **Green light:** Someone seeking, willing, and wanting to hear more about following Jesus.

Even if someone is a red light, we need to be friends with them and love them. However, you'll want to spend more time investing in green and yellow lights.

Part of Your Life

At Garden City Church, we believe that sharing your faith is an integral part of your Christian journey. Our primary goal is to equip you with the teachings and ministries necessary for experiencing the power and presence of Jesus and to empower you to become an effective witness.

Serving in Relational Ministries

You can also serve in ministries that intentionally build relationships with people. Consider participating in our CORE Ministry, the Landing Team, the Facilities Team, or serving in the Youth or Children's Ministry. These opportunities immediately connect you with our community.

Additionally, if you have a vision or passion you'd like to express at our church, perhaps God is calling you to initiate something new. Speak with Pastor Aaron to explore how your passion aligns with our vision.

AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH

We believe in authenticity. That includes sharing your faith. Telling people about Jesus is an essential part of following Jesus. We cannot tell people about God unless we have built credibility.

Inviting Guests

At Garden City Church, our services are intentionally designed to promote an inviting environment. We cultivate a relaxed atmosphere where every first-time guest feels welcome and comfortable - despite their attire or background. We strive to consider those coming through our door who may have no religious background.

A straightforward way to start sharing your faith is by inviting someone you've built a relationship with to join you for a weekend service. You can meet up at the service, enjoy a coffee together, and afterwards, continue the conversation over lunch or dinner to discuss what you experienced.

Mission Trips

Mission trips provide another avenue to express your faith. Throughout the year, we organize trips to various parts of the world. Due to limited space, we accept applications and select individuals who demonstrate a strong commitment to our community. On these missions, we not only share the message and hope of Jesus but also provide practical assistance to those in need, particularly in disadvantaged communities around the world. This is an ongoing endeavor, so stay tuned for updates and opportunities to get involved.

Sharing Your Faith - Discussion

Share your journey to faith in Christ in two minutes or less.

What scares you the most about sharing your faith? Why?

Do you have “people of peace” in your life? Who are they? How do you know?

How can you be a little more intentional with sharing your faith?

ACTION ITEM

Start to find one or two people you can begin to build a relationship with. Look around in your workplace, family, and neighborhood. Begin to take steps to share your faith in Christ authentically.

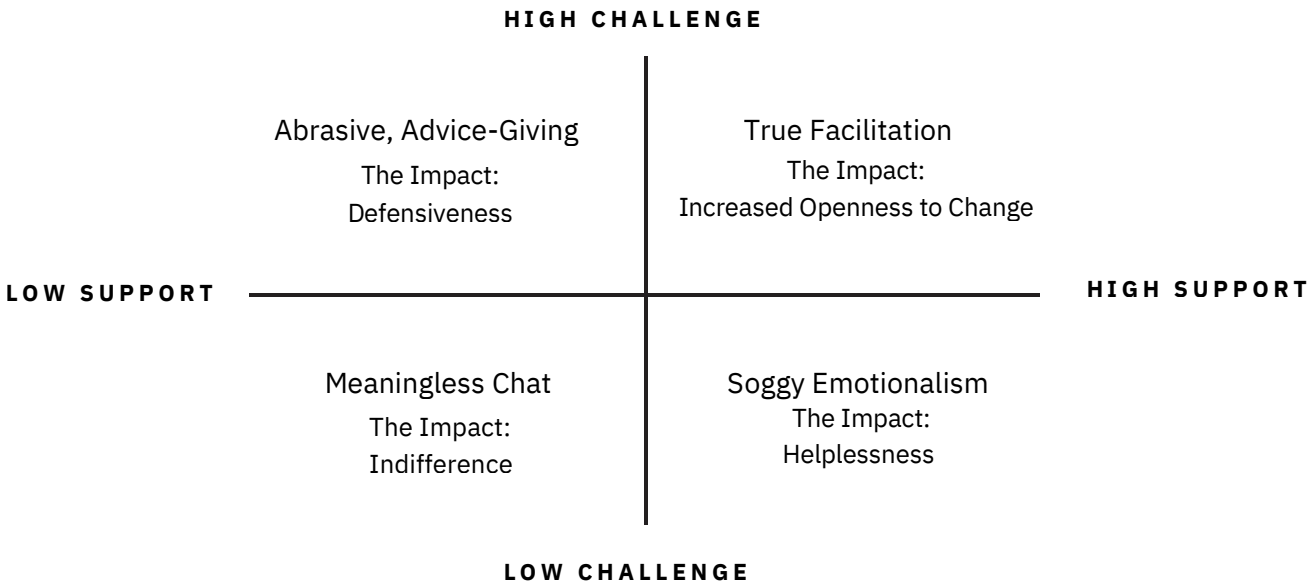
EXTRAS

There are numerous resources for sharing your faith. However, two that are clear and relevant to our culture are *The 9 Arts of Spiritual Conversations* by Mary Schaller and John Crilly. The other is *Starting Point* by Andy Stanley.

It cannot be emphasized enough, however, that sharing your faith involves building a meaningful relationship and should not be reduced to a formula or Bible tract. They don't care what you know until they know you care.

True Facilitation

When it comes to sharing our faith, we must challenge people and their way of thinking. If we truly love people, then we will be willing to challenge them. This chart is a great picture of how Jesus followers should challenge another person's thinking if they are not yet a Jesus follower themselves. We want to aim for "true facilitation" of change, which means we have high support (or high love) mixed with high challenge.



Week 7 - Discipleship

THE GREAT COMMAND

Following Jesus revolves around the greatest commandment. When Jesus was on earth, He was asked by a religious leader: “Which command is the most important of all?” Jesus replied:

> *“The most important is Listen, Israel! The Lord our God, the Lord is one. Love the Lord your God with all your heart, with all your soul, with all your mind, and with all your strength. The second is, Love your neighbor as yourself. There is no other command greater than these.” –Mark 12:28-31*

Everything we do to follow Jesus proceeds from these two commands. So, we should probably understand them at a deeper level. It’s not enough to just say, “love God and love others.” We must know what that actually means! C.S. Lewis once said, “There is no neutral ground in the universe. Every square inch, every split second is claimed by God, and counterclaimed by Satan.” Therefore, every part of us must love God, or else it loves Satan. There isn’t room for the “in-between.”

With All Your Heart

Loving God with all our heart means putting nothing above Him. It begins with our heart. As Jesus says, “Where your treasure is, there your heart will be also” (Matthew 6:21). We can easily let money, possessions, people, and even religion take precedence over our love for God. What are your priorities?

With All Your Soul

We must also love God with all our souls. This means surrendering the very depths of our being to Him, confessing our sins, and purifying our souls. While you don't need to share everything with everyone, you do need to share everything with someone.

The Christian writer Thomas Merton once said, “Every moment and every event of every [person’s] life on earth plants something in his soul.” We all carry something in our souls; it’s inevitable. The question is: what are you doing about it? Loving God with our soul means addressing the junk, hurt, and pride within us.

With All Your Mind

What consumes your mind each day? Is it the news cycle, sports, or opinions that lack truth? We should prioritize filling our minds with God. This means dedicating time to reading Scripture and consuming information that glorifies Him. Pursuing hobbies is fine, but we must assess whether they truly align with loving God with all our minds!

Loving God with all our minds involves saturating our thoughts with godly wisdom. Each day, countless distractions vie for our attention. It's crucial to be deliberate about what we allow into our minds.

With All Your Strength

Loving God with all our strength requires focused effort. Our relationship with Jesus is deeply influenced by the effort we exert, even when we stumble. Perfection isn't expected, but our sincerity and determination are evident to God. With the Holy Spirit's assistance, we are empowered to fulfill the Great Commandment.

LOVING OTHERS

Out of our deep love for God flows love for others, fulfilling the second part of the Great Commandment. What does it mean to love people? Jesus illustrates this through the parable of the Good Samaritan in Luke 10. Luke recounts this powerful story to teach us a fundamental principle of loving others:

> *"A man was going down from Jerusalem to Jericho and fell into the hands of robbers. They stripped him, beat him up, and fled, leaving him half dead. A priest happened to be going down that road. When he saw him, he passed by on the other side. In the same way, a Levite, when he arrived at the place and saw him, passed by on the other side. But a Samaritan on his journey came up to him, and when he saw the man,* ***he had compassion. He went over to him and bandaged his wounds, pouring on olive oil and wine.*** *Then he put him on his own animal, brought him to an inn, and took care of him. The next day he took out two denarii, gave them to the innkeeper, and said,* ***'Take care of him. When I come back I'll reimburse you for whatever extra you spend.'*** *'Which of these three do you think proved to be a neighbor to the man who fell into the hands of the robbers?" "The one who showed mercy to him," he said. Then Jesus told him, 'Go and do the same' [emphasis added]." –Luke 10:30-37*

A lot of people interpret this parable as helping people on the side of the road who are in financial need. It can be that, of course. However, that is not the full point. The parable Jesus tells illuminates three key principles for loving people.

> *"Then an expert in the law stood up to test him, saying, 'Teacher, what must I do to inherit eternal life?' 'What is written in the law?' he asked him. 'How do you read it?' He answered, 'Love the Lord your God with all your heart, with all your soul, with all your strength, and with all your mind,' and 'your neighbor as yourself.' 'You've answered correctly,' he told him. 'Do this and you will live.' But wanting to justify himself, he asked Jesus, 'And who is my neighbor?'" –Luke 10:25-29*

1. Actually Care for People

We are called to love everyone we encounter in our daily lives, showing genuine care for them. The Good Samaritan, upon seeing the man on the roadside, felt compassion and acted upon it.

2. Notice the Need

Loving people involves recognizing a need and offering assistance. Like the Good Samaritan who tended to the wounds of the man left by the roadside, sometimes those wounds are not immediately visible, requiring us to pay attention and be present to offer help.

3. Go Above and Beyond

We are called to exceed ordinary expectations for others. The Good Samaritan went beyond what was required to assist the injured man on the road. As followers of Jesus, our love should reflect a radical difference in the world. Sometimes, this means stopping in the driveway to engage with our neighbors instead of simply pulling into the garage and closing the door.

! Our love for God is expressed in our love for people. Our love for people is what should compel them back to God. However, we will never make disciples if we don't love God and love people.

Discipleship

THE GREAT COMMISSION

The Great Commandment should always lead us to fulfill the Great Commission. We apply the principles of the Great Commandment as we live out the Great Commission. When Jesus physically departed from His disciples for the last time, He entrusted them with this commission:

> *"All authority has been given to me in heaven and on earth. Go, therefore, and make disciples of all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, teaching them to observe everything I have commanded you. And remember, I am with you always, to the end of the age." –Matthew 28:18-20*

If you've been in church for any length of time, you've likely heard about the Great Commission (we've mentioned it in previous lessons). It's perhaps the most quoted Scripture related to sharing the gospel or evangelism. While sharing our faith is important, making disciples of Jesus is a deliberate process and the ultimate goal of sharing our faith with others.

Being Mentored and Mentoring Others

Discipleship is not instantaneous; it begins with baptism and involves a journey of learning and growing to become more like Jesus over time. However, our growth is most effective when someone invests intentional time in guiding us. A disciple is someone who chooses to follow Jesus (head knowledge), undergoes transformation to become more like Him (heart change), and actively serves and makes disciples (practical service with our hands). Genuine discipleship often requires the mentorship and guidance of others. Jesus Himself exemplified this by investing time and teaching in twelve disciples, who in turn mentored and guided others, continuing the chain of discipleship. Ultimately, every follower of Jesus is called to invest in mentoring others in their faith journey. Without actively making disciples, we cannot truly claim to be followers of Jesus.

There are different forms of discipleship. As you read the account of Jesus and His life, you clearly see different groups where discipleship takes place.

Jesus and the Crowds

Jesus taught many things to crowds, which sometimes reached 5,000 people. He was discipling people through His teachings. A weekend service perhaps is a very basic form of discipleship - allowing people to gather for teaching.

Jesus and the People

Even though Jesus taught crowds, He was often found visiting people at their homes. Jesus is seen hanging out at many homes, including those belonging to Mary and Martha, Zacchaeus, and the tax collector Matthew. He taught important things there. This class or other social learning environments would best reflect this form of discipleship.

Jesus and the Group

Yet, Jesus also had a small group that He invested in. He had 12 people that He selected and walked with over time. It was in this group that He described His teachings further. A modern small group or CORE Minister group might be a biblical equivalent to Jesus' discipleship model.

Jesus and the Three

Despite these other forms of discipleship, the most effective is when a small group of people dig deeper. Jesus took Peter, James, and John and poured intentional, exclusive time with them. It was these three who were the pillars of the Church. Our success truly depends on the smaller forms of discipleship. This is what some would call the "transparent space" and can be best executed by using a few simple discipleship tools.

DISCIPLESHIP AT GARDEN CITY CHURCH

At Garden City Church, we are deeply committed to loving God, loving people, and making disciples. Our mission is to cultivate genuine followers of Jesus. We believe in God's profound love, which embraces us unconditionally wherever we are. He is compassionate and accepts us despite our sins, backgrounds, or past experiences. Yet, His love is transformative; as we draw nearer to Him, He challenges us to grow and change. Consider the fruit of the Holy Spirit—allowing God to work in us prompts His Spirit to shape our character. In other words - God loves us too much to leave us in the condition in which He found us.

In our community, we strive to love people unconditionally. While we embrace everyone as they are, we also love them enough to encourage growth. As you participate in this class, we invite you to embrace the challenge of taking your next step in faith.

Discipleship Steps

At Garden City Church, a crucial step in our discipleship journey is discovering how to disciple others. After completing the 'Following Jesus' course, we invite you to join 'Authentic Discipleship', 'The Holy Spirit Class', and connect with a CORE Minister.

These opportunities will equip you with the concepts, identity, and practices needed to become a disciple-maker. They provide a foundation for living out the Great Commission."

Next Steps

We offer several next steps, all detailed on our Next Steps page. Don't feel overwhelmed or delay—take a step towards community, growth, and service. Engaging in this process will shape you to resemble Jesus more closely, and as you grow more like Him, you'll contribute to changing our world."

TOOLS OF DISCIPLESHIP

DISCIPLESHIP TOOL #1:

An easy way to start discipling with a few other people is through the Great Command. Remember, we use the Great Command to live the Great Commission. When you start meeting with someone for discipleship, you begin by checking in with these guiding questions based on the Great Command:

How are You Loving God with Your Heart?

In other words: What has been the most important thing in your life this week? Finances? Work? Hobbies? How can you shift things to make God our priority? Jesus says: "where your treasure is, that's where your heart is as well" (Matthew 6:21). Where is your treasure?

How are You Loving God with Your Soul?

In other words: Deep within you, is there anything eating away at you? This is not a place to correct or judge. It's an honest invitation to share and grow with one another.

How are You Loving God with Your Mind?

In other words: What have you been filling your mind with this week? What have you been watching, listening to, reading, etc.? Again, this is an open, non-judgmental space for people to share.

Have You Been Loving Others Around You?

This could include spouse, family, friends, co-workers, etc.

DISCIPLESHIP TOOL #2: TRUTH-TREK

"To live out the Great Commission and learn everything Jesus commanded, we have to get into God's Word and obey it. Truth Trek is a Sunday morning Sunday School class at Garden City Church where we walk you through the Bible step by step. This journey into Scripture not only helps us grow spiritually but also guides us to live obediently, fulfilling the Great Commission with accountability, sharing the Gospel, and serving others."

Discipleship - Discussion

What are some things that rule your heart? Do you struggle to put God in front of money or possessions?

Why is it so difficult to expose our souls, even to God? What steps can we take to reveal our souls to God and others?

What are some unhealthy and healthy things we fill our minds with? What are some ways we can consistently love God with our minds?

What does discipleship mean to you? Have you been discipled or discipled others? Share that experience.

What do you think your next step is?

Next Steps

WHAT'S NEXT?

"Your next steps at Garden City Church include linking up with a CORE Minister who can walk alongside you, provide encouragement, and support you on your discipleship journey.

Additionally, we invite you to participate in Sunday Morning Truth Trek, join us for 5am Prayer, or Tuesday Night Prayer. Making yourself available to live, learn, and grow spiritually is essential to your journey."

ACTION ITEM

Take your next step! Talk with your group (or church team) and determine where you should serve (if you don't already). Then determine where you will continue to grow as a Jesus follower. We also need community. Either join a Life Group, start one, or invite someone into a group you might already have. Finally, make the determination if you need to start discipling or if you need to ask someone to disciple you. Whatever it is, do not neglect to take your next step!

Notes



Garden City Church
www.gardencitychurch.net
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